

tiny sunburned cherub, with twinkling eyes and a nervous laugh, among a sea of writerly wisecracks and calibrated couture, Allah Rakka Rahman stood out at the Oscars both for his multiculturalism and for his otherworldliness. A snatch of a dialogue from *Deewar*, another saying in Tamil, and a smart nod in these divided times to the Sufi philosophy of choosing love over hate, and it was clear that Rahman the recluse had become Rahman the rock star. Not just hugely talented but also impossibly cool, surer in the spotlight than ever before, acknowledging a red carpet thumbs up from Brad Pitt and being gushed over by Kate Winslet.

It was a day few in India will forget, and a dizzying few days the *Slumdog Millionaire* cast and crew will never forget. A visit to Disneyland for the six children, and Madhur Mittal: a Woody Allen movie for Freida Pinto; extended chats with Hollywood immortals for Anil Kapoor; and a long night of partying for everyone, whirling from the Governor's Ball, to the Fox Searchlight do, ultimately to the coveted party hosted by *Vanity Fair*, which just featured Danny Boyle and Dev Patel in its Hollywood portfolio by Annie Leibovitz. And yes, a third Oscar for India, for sound mixing, shared with Richard Pryke and Ian Tapp, for Resul Pookutty, that finicky, talented and hugely eloquent sound engineer from Mumbai. After just two Oscars till now, Best Costume Designer



for Bhanu Athaiya for *Gandhi* (1982) and Lifetime Achievement Award for Satyajit Ray in 1992, three at one go is seeing the kinds of celebrations usually reserved for a big cricket win.

Rahman's star burned the brightest though. It's not happened overnight. The rock star was always in residence (indeed, in his youth, he was a member of not one but five rock bands) but just not interested in promoting himself. "I didn't say much earlier because I didn't have much to say," he says. Even now, one of his first concerns has been that he should not be "everywhere" and people should not be sick of him. No chance of it as of now.

The *Jai ho* steamroller is rolling along. He's been interviewed by *The New York Times* and *The Los Angeles Times*. He's sung *Jai ho* on *The Tonight Show* with Jay Leno and explained to Oprah Winfrey what the two words mean (may victory be yours, he said, smiling). He's also getting ready for life after the two golden men. "If the first decade of his work was about making music for Tamil and then Hindi films, the second was about taking his sound to Hindi films and then to the world. The third, beginning now, will be about global collaboration," says his long-time friend, Vijay Mohan Iyer.

The seeds have long been in place. The KM Music Conser-



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the number of awards Rahman has won till now around the world

Other Honours

Slumdog Millionaire was nominated for 10 Oscars and won eight, for its heart and soul

BEST PICTURE
In a year of depressing films such as *The Reader*, *Milk* and *Frost/Nixon*, *Slumdog* shone

BEST DIRECTOR
Danny Boyle dedicates the win to Mumbai, "unending, inseparable, unborn"

FILM EDITING
Chris Dickens' non-linear structure works for a story told as a thriller

CINEMATOGRAPHY
Anthony Dod Mantle, who's worked on several international films gets a lot of help from Raj Acharya

BEST SOUND MIXING
Slumdog wins over blockbusters like *The Dark Knight* and *Wall-E*

BEST ADAPTED SCREENPLAY
Simon Beaufoy, nominated in 1997 for *The Full Monty*, wins this time